abused by fascism out of hopelessness, to give their lives new meaning and new goals, and to involve them in the struggle to overcome fascism, militarism and imperialism'.13

In a quiet interval during his strenuous work-life, Honecker tied the knot with Charlotte at the Berlin-Mitte registry office before a small group of friends. The marriage certificate states his employment as 'Secretary Honecker', and Charlotte – full name: Gertrud Margarete Charlotte Schanuel – as a 'Wachtmeisterin' (constable/patrol woman). There was no wedding album nor honeymoon, and Honecker's comrades turned a blind eye to Charlotte's Nazi past. However, despite a seemingly happy start, the groom soon tired of his new wife – there were violent tantrums, made worse by her refusal to join the SED. He was deeply hurt when she refused to stop working – saying she enjoyed her career and wanted to continue with it. From here on, relations cooled rapidly and Honecker devoted more time to work.

He grew in stature as a rising figure in the Party and frequently mixed with Wilhelm Pieck, widely regarded to be the most charismatic figure in the German communist movement, a man Honecker thought the embodiment of decency, duty and tradition: 'I was filled with joyful excitement that suddenly I was faced with a man who epitomised the best traditions of the German Workers Movement.' Remembering this period, Honecker's right-hand man at the FDJ, Heinz Lippmann, recounted when it came to personal relationships, his boss was not a man to act impulsively nor rush into anything. 'He had a very unassuming manner and seemed very receptive to other people's ideas and suggestions and always ready to learn.' Fraternising with bourgeois and clerical types was something he never enjoyed. 'In a closed group of comrades, he made no secret of it,' Lippmann divulged. 'It was hard for him to feign friendliness and tolerance with middle-class people.' Ivan Bedin, a youth officer with the SMAD, thought Honecker displayed an unassuming demeanour, 'he was a lean man,' he recounted, 'more than humble, but charged with colossal energy, who was able to inspire others'.14

During this period, he became a much more confident writer, penning articles on sport, agriculture, class unity and threats to the socialist way of